

FACTIONS

“When you play the game of thrones, you win or you die. There is no middle ground.”

– GEORGE R.R. MARTIN, A GAME OF THRONES

Factions are groups of NPCs who have interests that can align with or come into conflict with those of the player characters. In a typical Dragonbane adventure, you should have at least three factions major with distinct goals and methods.

These factions should have interests that are either diametrically opposed or at least frequently come into conflict with each other. Their struggle for control and victory can then generate a dynamic background to your ongoing adventure setting.

FACTION FEATURES

Factions have **GOALS** they want to achieve, for which they deploy **UNITS** and **ASSETS** inside a settlement or to one of the major adventure sites in the region.

GOALS: A faction undertakes mission with certain goals to enhance their power or progress towards its overall end goal. Typical faction goals include: recruiting new agents and underlings; searching new assets in adventure sites; increasing their power in a settlement; or attacking a rival faction – covertly or openly.

UNITS: The most visible part of a faction are the units they send out into the world. There are two types of units: **AGENTS**, like knights or spies, work alone; **GROUPS** include about four to six low-raknig faction members – one more than the player characters.

ASSETS: Factions own real estate, tamed monsters, wealth or powerful magic items that they can use to further their goals. Assets can’t do anything on their own but must either be used from the faction headquarters or wielded by an agent on a mission – although that bears the risk of falling into enemy hands.

FACTION REPUTATION

You can use the [Dragonbrew - Reputation](#) rules to track the PCs standing with each of the factions. Directly aiding or interfering with a faction’s mission counts as an extraordinary deed (three lines on the list).

SETTING UP MISSIONS

Factions undertake missions to further their goals, which change the situation around the player characters. Set up new missions and resolve ongoing missions between sessions so that the world changes once the PCs return to a settlement from an adventure site.

A faction can only plan a mission if they have a free **UNIT** to assign to it. Missions always aim at a faction **GOAL**, like searching for assets in an adventure site, recruiting more followers in a settlement, attacking an enemy, or opposing a rival faction’s efforts.

RUMORS TABLE: Unless a faction deploys a secret agent, a faction move adds an entry to the rumors table or card deck available to the players – something like “The brotherhood is searching for an ancient temple in the Thornwood” or “The thieves guild is recruiting again”.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS: Faction units can be encountered during travel if they frequently to and from the adventure site, if they keep guard posts or patrols in the surrounding area, or when they are still searching for a well-hidden adventure site. Decide whether they are generally hostile, neutral or friendly towards the PCs.

ADVENTURE STIES: If a faction move sends a unit to an adventure site, it takes a certain amount of time to complete. A simple mission only takes up to a week; More complex missions can take several weeks, during which time the units will be present at the site and can be helped or hindered by the PCs or another faction’s units.

RESOLVING MISSIONS

Before setting up new missions between sessions, check whether any ongoing missions can be resolved.

If the PCs have get involved in a faction’s ongoing mission, the mission is resolved according to what happened during play. **UNITS** or **ASSETS** can either be lost or won for the involved faction.

If the PCs are not involved with a mission that is about to end, roll on the highest relevant skill of all involved **UNITS**. If the roll succeeds, the mission is successful and the faction gains a new **UNIT** or **ASSET**, depending on the pursued **GOAL**. If it fails, their efforts are hindered and the mission is aborted.

- ✦ If a rival faction opposes the mission, resolve both sides with an open opposed roll, only the winning side succeeds in their mission.
- ✦ On a dragon, the winning faction gains twice as many rewards, but on a demon, one of the **UNITS** or **ASSETS** in play is lost.



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EXAMPLE FACTIONS

RULE OF THREE

You can use the “the good, the bad, and the ugly” rule of thumb to create the major three factions in your adventure setting:

THE GOOD: A self-righteous faction, like a knights’ order or religious institution that seeks to spread law and order. However, their “goodness” can be questionable.

THE BAD: A chaotic faction that uses stealth and subterfuge to achieve its selfish and power-hungry ambitions. They can be allied to the PCs but will likely betray them.

THE UGLY: This faction can be any wild or untamable horde, like a nightkin clan, barbarian tribe or band of pirates. To ally with them, the PCs must first prove themselves.



THE KNIGHTS OF THE CLEANSING FIRE

Another offshoot of the Keepers of the Immaculate Flame, these knights see themselves as the only true heirs to the ancient dragon knights of emperor Eledain. The order stands for the cleansing of the corrupted with fire and sword, and adhere to strict codes of purity, truth, duty, and order. They too seek to re-establish Eledain’s empire, but hold that the other sects of self-proclaimed dragon knights have fallen off the one true path. They have adopted Eledain’s all-seeing eye surrounded by pure flame as their symbol.

Their primary goal is to oppose the machinations of the demon prince Beliel in the south and hunt his followers and cultists with a fierce determination.

UNITS: The three dragon knights Thorfinn, Mereniel and Herderik (**AGENTS**); Hired adventurers (**GROUP**)

ASSETS: An ancient longsword, warhammer, and morningstar that all glow when demons are nearby

GOALS:

- ◆ Recruit squires or hire mercenaries (+**UNIT**)
- ◆ Uncover ancient dragon empire artefacts (+**ASSET**)
- ◆ Bring cultists **GROUPS** or **AGENTS** to swift justice



BELIEL CULTISTS

The demon prince Beliel is the incarnation of malice, cruelty, deception, lies, selfishness, corruption, and the achievement of power over others. He hails from a demonic realm of madness and chaos. He seeks to enter the mortal world to dominate its inhabitants and so expand his domain.

Beliel’s worshippers wear his demonic mark branded somewhere on their body, usually on their forearm hidden under their clothes. The mark is a stylized depiction of Beliel’s twisted horns.

UNITS: The demon cultists (**GROUP**); The secret agent Mara – aka “Alina” (**AGENT**); Shell the assassin (**AGENT**)

ASSETS: Demonic messenger bats; A ritual to summon a demon (**SUMMON CHAMPION**, Book of Magic p.32)

GOALS:

- ◆ Recruit inconspicuous villagers into the cult (+**UNIT**)
- ◆ Find powerful magic spells and items (+**ASSET**)
- ◆ Covertly assassinate a rival faction **AGENT**



THE NIGHTKIN HORDE

A mighty orc chieftain Harkar has united the orcs, goblins, hobgoblins and even a few ogres under her banner. This horde stands for freedom, independence, the law of the blade, rule of the strong and the wild pride of the various nightkins.

The nightkin see themselves as the rightful rulers of this land and view the “daykin” – especially humans and halflings – as trespassers on their ancestral ground. They rally under Harkar’s flag of the double slashed scar.

UNITS: Goblin scouts (**GROUP**); Orc warriors (**GROUP**); The orcish shaman Karakmûl (**AGENT**); The ogre twins Mog and Mrak (**AGENTS**)

ASSETS: A war camp hidden in a densely wooded mountain valley; A small pack of riding worgs

GOALS:

- ◆ Raise a champion among the ranks (+**AGENT**)
- ◆ Raid a nearby daykin farm or village (+**ASSET**)
- ◆ Defeat a daykin **GROUP** or **AGENT** in combat